

The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra Called 'The Twelve Buddhas'

Ārya-dvādaśabuddhi-ka-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra · Toh 273 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་སངས་རྒྱལ་བའི་པ་ཞེས་བ་བྱ་བའི་པ་ཆེ་པའི་མཛན།

Toh 273 in the Kangyur is a Mahāyāna sūtra known in English as "The Twelve Buddhas," in Sanskrit as the Ārya-dvādaśabuddhika-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra, and in Tibetan as Pakpa Sangye Chunyi Shyewa Zhejawa Tekpa Chenpo'i Do. It belongs to the general class of Mahāyāna sūtras and takes the form of a teaching delivered by the Buddha on Vulture Peak Mountain at Rājagṛha, addressed to the bodhisattva Maitreya, in which the Buddha describes buddha-fields and the buddhas presiding over them in the eastern direction and beyond. The text was translated into Tibetan by the great editor-translator, the monk Yeshé Dé, together with the Indian scholar Varma and others.

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In the language of India: Ārya-dvādaśabuddhi-ka-nāma-mahāyāna-sūtra.

In the Tibetan language: The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra Called "The Twelve Buddhas."

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling on Vulture Peak Mountain at Rājagṛha together with a great Saṅgha of twelve hundred and fifty monks, and together also with a great bodhisattva Saṅgha of twenty-two thousand bodhisattvas, headed by the bodhisattva Ajita and others.

Then the Blessed One spoke to the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya:

Maitreya, beyond this buddha-field, in the eastern direction, past buddha-fields as numerous as the atoms of ten times a hundred thousand myriads of kotis of buddha-fields beyond reckoning, there exists a world-system called "The Pearly." In that world-system there presently dwells, and is alive and abides, and also teaches the Dharma, a Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha whose name is Splendor of Space, Stainless, Dispeller of Dust, Supremely Beautiful, Jewel-Crest of Qualities, Light, Lotus-Flower, Blazing with Vaidūrya Radiance, Possessing a Body Resembling Precious Form, Worshipped with the Finest Excellent Incense, His Body Adorned and Well

Ornamented, From the Crown of His Uṣṇīṣa Radiating Immeasurable Rays of the Sun, Adorned with Moonlight Aspirations, Greatly Manifest and Arrayed, Arisen Beyond from the Dharmadhātu, Free from Attachment, King of Jewels.

Whoever holds the name of that Victor — for great eons as numerous as the atoms of Jambudvīpa — shall turn back from cyclic existence.

That buddha prophesied the bodhisattva, the great being called "Stainless," saying that he shall, immediately upon the passing into nirvāṇa of that Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha — Splendor of Space, Stainless, Dispeller of Dust, Supremely Beautiful, Jewel-Crest of Qualities, Light, Lotus-Flower, Blazing with Vaiḍūrya Radiance, Possessing a Body Resembling Precious Form, Worshipped with the Finest Excellent Incense, His Body Adorned and Well Ornamented, From the Crown of His Uṣṇīṣa Radiating Immeasurable Rays of the Sun, Adorned with Moonlight Aspirations, Greatly Manifest and Arrayed, Arisen Beyond from the Dharmadhātu, Free from Attachment, King of Jewels — immediately upon that buddha's complete passing into nirvāṇa and the decline of his sacred Dharma, fully awaken to unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening, and shall arise in the world as the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha, endowed with knowledge and conduct, the Sugata, Knower of the World, Unsurpassable Guide of Persons to be Tamed, Teacher of Gods and Humans, the Blessed Buddha, whose name is Young Water-God, Lamp of the Sun, Moon-Flower, Jeweled Lotus, Golden Beauty, Possessing a Body Like Space, Vairocana (the Illuminator), Supremely Adorned with Rays, Unobstructed Wheel-Maṇḍala, Pouring Forth Rays in All Ten Directions, Illuminating All World-Systems, Victory Banner Crest, King.

That very Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha of that same eastern direction shall also bear the name: All-Arrayed Stainless Light.

Recite this aloud. Bow in homage.

The Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha of the southern direction shall also bear the name: Vast Aspiration Adorned with the Ornament of Confidence.

Hold this in mind.

The Tathāgata of the western direction, Stainless, King of the Moon's Crest, the Renowned — shall also bear this name.

Bow in homage.

The Tathāgata of the northern direction, Illuminator of the Arrangement of Flowers — shall also bear this name.

Bow in homage.

The Tathāgata of the south-eastern direction shall also bear the name: Maker of Light.

Bow in homage.

The Tathāgata of the south-western direction shall also bear the name: Renowned Crest of the Supreme Jewel.

Bow in homage.

The Tathāgata of the north-western direction shall also bear the name: Fearless All-Beholding.

Bow in homage.

The Tathāgata of the north-eastern direction shall also bear the name: Free from Fear, Without Shame, Causing No Bristling of the Hair.

Bow in homage.

The Tathāgata of the direction below shall also bear the name: Throat Adorned with a Lion's Mane.

Bow in homage.

The Tathāgata of the direction above shall also bear the name: Golden Light, Splendor, Fearless King.

Bow in homage.

O Maitreya, son or daughter of good family who has faith: recite the names of these twelve Blessed Ones, Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas. For ten days, confess all the faults of every wrongdoing. Rejoice in all wholesome roots. Urge all buddhas onward, and beseech all buddhas. Dedicate all wholesome roots by dedicating them fully into the dharmadhātu, the basic space of phenomena. Through this, all wrongdoing shall be exhausted, and all karmic obscurations shall be completely purified.

After that, one shall also attain the excellence of the arrangement of qualities of buddha fields, excellence of fearlessness, excellence of major marks, excellence of the Saṅgha of bodhisattvas, excellence of dhāraṇīs, and excellence of meditative absorption. Just as one aspires, one shall swiftly hold

the excellence of perfectly pure buddha fields and the excellence of spiritual friends. One shall not fall away from unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening, nor shall one utterly fall away. And even while wandering in saṃsāra, one shall hold perfect beauty, excellence of wealth and enjoyment, excellence of lineage, excellence of birth, excellence of family clan, excellence of form, and excellence of a retinue of beings of similar kind.

On this, the following is said:

In whatever place and wherever one is born,
in every single lifetime after lifetime,
one becomes a source of joy to behold and a cause of joy in others,
a maker of light, one of great power,
and one who comes to great prosperity.

These dhāraṇī mantra bases (Skt. dhāraṇī-mantra) are also to be recited:

Tadyathā: akhe makhe samantamukhe sauti yugte nirugte prabhāsamayoge
cittavivṛte ame khame madane vivṛte samantagaṇe satyarama yugte
prayugte hilimili masale ānale came aciṭi aciṭi coce arahe bahudtse
māyugrahe hemavati jyotivati dharmaciti cyutavaṃke avikṣepe radhikṣame
skandhavibhakate.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas. By the blessing of the buddhas, may these dhāraṇī mantra bases be accomplished.

On this, the following is said:

If one holds these dhāraṇīs,
the sixty million sages dwelling
throughout the ten directions
shall turn their minds toward that person.

In every single birth,
one shall find a spiritual friend.

Whatever small amount of virtue there may be,
all aims shall come to be fulfilled.

The buddhas dwelling at the heart of the lotus
shall be seen face to face.

One who holds these dhāraṇīs —

one is gloriously born as a wise being.
Mindfulness, intelligence, and realization,
aspiration and wisdom, shall all greatly increase.

All that one hears shall be retained,
and nothing heard shall ever be forgotten.

Whoever recites the names of these protectors of the world,
having cast aside all lower destinies,
shall swiftly travel to the higher realms.
The supreme meditative absorption and dhāraṇī
shall become fully manifest for that person.
Complete awakening shall be swiftly attained.

The accumulation of merit belonging to one who holds
the names of the Tathāgatas
surpasses that of one who fills a billion worlds with gold and makes offering
thereof.

One shall continually recall one's past lives.
While practicing the conduct of the bodhisattva path,
all unfree states shall be utterly abandoned.
One shall attain a gloriously fine birth at the arising of a buddha,
and bring joy to the fully awakened ones.
One shall obtain supreme, unsurpassable faith.
With deep confidence in the buddhas,
one shall perform excellent offerings.
Rejoicing in the arising of a buddha,
one shall behold the Teacher and be filled with pure faith.
Beholding the lamp of the world,
one shall perform exquisite offerings.

One who holds these names
shall, across innumerable tens of millions of eons,
completely abandon cyclic existence
and swiftly attain awakening.

If one holds these names fully for seven consecutive days,
the vast eyes through which the guides are seen
shall become purified.

Whoever holds the names of these protectors of the world,
in whatever birth and wherever they are born,
shall become worthy of veneration.

One who holds these names
shall not, throughout tens of millions of inconceivable eons,
come to receive dishonor,
and shall attain renown throughout the worlds.

One who holds these names,
the gods shall pay homage to that person for many eons.
Awakening shall be swiftly attained.

One who holds these names,
though devoted in aspiration, shall not lose wisdom.
Deceit and guile shall be thoroughly abandoned,
and one shall always behold the buddhas.

One who holds these names,
gods, gandharvas, lords of nāgas,
garuḍas, asuras, and secret-keepers
shall always guard that person.

One shall be born with excellent form and features
in a great wealthy household,
and shall make gifts to all sentient beings,
being courageous and generous, with no trace of miserliness.

For many hundreds of tens of millions of eons,
the fragrance of the divine red sandalwood
and of all supremely sweet-smelling incenses
shall arise from that person's mouth.

One who holds these names,
for tens of millions of eons, shall possess a voice
endowed with the tones of Brahmā,
and shall always be graced with the manner of a Dharma king.

One who holds these names shall be born
amid many billions and thousands of lotus petals of the seven precious
substances,
greatly prosperous and possessed of a divine form.

Whoever holds these names
shall never be seen to be parted
from parents, dear relatives,
the assembly of people, or beloved companions.

If a woman holds the names of the great sages,
through not becoming attached to a woman's body,
she shall be reborn as a man endowed with intelligence.
Having obtained a human body,
she shall attain unsurpassable awakening,
shall set the wheel of Dharma greatly turning,
and shall pass into nirvāṇa as she wishes.

Whoever holds these names,
weapons, poison, fire, kings,
and those of ill intent shall not be able to harm their body.

Whoever holds these names,
Māra with his armies and his mounts
shall never find an opportunity
to assail that person's mind.

Whoever holds the names among these,
that person shall travel through space
across countless tens of millions of buddha fields,
pay homage to the buddha-teachers,
and present requests without fear.
Those Victors, knowing that person's thoughts,
shall bestow upon that one a prophecy.

Having received a prophecy
from those protector buddhas,
that one shall be filled with great joy
and hold no doubts concerning the teaching of the Victors.

Whoever holds these names
shall hear the profound Dharma
from those protectors of the world,
and having heard, shall retain it all.

Thereafter, the perfections,
fearlessness and the powers,
the major marks and the excellent minor marks —
all without exception shall be perfected.

In whichever buddha field
those buddhas now abide,

that one shall come to understand
unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening
and attain full buddhahood.

Whether man or woman,
whoever holds these names —
these qualities and others beyond them
shall be spoken by buddhas throughout endless aeons.

Having become endowed with heedfulness,
and having heard of these sublime qualities,
those persons shall hold the names
of the renowned, perfectly complete buddhas.

These buddhas, glorious and essential,
kings among clouds, supreme among humans,
protectors of the world —
whoever listens to their names for even an aeon,
whoever hears and reveres these names,
shall come to possess vast wisdom
and shall become the highest among two-footed beings.

If one hears the names of those great sages,
becomes endowed with heedfulness and skilled,
and is possessed of wisdom —
who would not hold them?

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the bodhisattva great being
Maitreya, those bodhisattvas, those monks, and the entire assembled retinue,
together with gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas — the whole world was
filled with joy and gave resounding praise to the words of the Blessed One.

The noble Mahāyāna sūtra called "The Twelve Buddhas" is complete.

Translator's Notes

- The long proper name of the eastern buddha is a compound Tibetan rendering of a Sanskrit buddhonāma, strung together as a single honorific epithet-chain. The translation renders each element sequentially as the text presents them, without conjunctions, following the liturgical style of the original. There is no single received Sanskrit reconstruction for this name, and different editions may show minor variation in the component epithets.

The phrase rendered "immediately upon the decline of his sacred Dharma" translates a construction indicating the very moment the Dharma of that preceding buddha has faded — a standard formula for the prophesied arising of a future buddha.

The ritual rubrics "Recite this aloud," "Bow in homage," and "Hold this in mind" are liturgical performance directions embedded in the Tibetan text and are rendered as such.

- The name rendered "Free from Fear, Without Shame, Causing No Bristling of the Hair" translates a compound name for the north-eastern Tathāgata. The third element, literally "not causing the hair to stand on end," refers to the absence of the fearful shuddering response; this is a recognized epithet pattern in buddha-name literature indicating the complete absence of terror.

The mantra syllables are transliterated as they appear in the Tibetan phonetic rendering; precise Sanskrit reconstruction of some syllables is uncertain, and the transliteration here follows the Tibetan closely rather than imposing a restored Sanskrit form.

The verse and prose end mid-sentence, reflecting that this is a continuous passage and the translation stops where the supplied Tibetan ends.

- The verse on women holding the names and consequently being reborn male reflects a classical Indian Buddhist motif found in many Mahāyāna sūtras. The text presents this straightforwardly as a reward; no emendation has been made.

The phrase rendered "secret-keepers" translates a term referring to vidyādhara or guhyakas, attendants associated with Vajrapāṇi and similar guardian figures; the Tibetan here most likely intends guhyaka-type beings rather than vidyādhara proper, though in some catalogues the two overlap.

- The closing epithet rendered "kings among clouds, supreme among humans" renders "sprin gyi rgyal po mi yi mchog" — "cloud-king" is a poetic epithet for the buddhas in question, suggesting they shower Dharma-rain as clouds shower water. This is a standard literary image in Indic and Tibetan Buddhist verse and requires no further comment.

The colophon phrase "'phags pa sangs rgyas bcu gnyis pa zhes bya ba theg pa chen po'i mdo rdzogs" confirms this is the conclusion of the complete sūtra; "rdzogs" meaning "complete" or "finished" is conventionally rendered as "is complete" in colophons.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.

